

3. Enjoy dairy products in moderation

Environment: Plant-based milk, except for rice milk, has a lower Carbon Footprint (CF) than dairy milk (Clune et al. 2017). The difference is even more significant for the Water Footprint (WF of soy milk is 296.9 L/kg vs cow's milk 1050 L/kg, Ercin et al. 2011). Yogurt has a value similar to milk, while cheese - due to the high concentration of milk used for its production - can have a CF and WF up to 6 times higher than the original milk. When compared with other protein sources, cheese has twice the WF of soy-based proteins, and both the CF and WF of cheese can be higher than those of many meat sources, including chicken, pork and fish (Clune et al. 2017, Mekonnen, M.M. and Hoekstra, A.Y., 2010).

Health: High intake of dairy products, at least three servings per day, has been widely promoted in Western countries for bone health and fracture prevention, primarily because of their high calcium content. However, the optimum calcium intake remains uncertain (Willett et al., 2019), while there is evidence that the adverse effect of protein of animal origin might outweigh the positive effect of calcium intake on the calcium balance (FAO and WHO, 2002). Animal-based dairy fat like butter conveys a higher risk of cardiovascular disease than unsaturated plant oils, which therefore should be preferred whenever possible for cooking and food preparation (EAT-Lancet Commission, Willett et al., 2019).

4. Avoid too much food

Environment: Every kilogram of food carries the embedded environmental impact generated during its production, processing, transportation, and packaging (Willett et al. 2019, Ercin et al. 2011, Clune et al. 2017, Vanham and Bigoglio, 2013). To reduce pressure on the environment, we need to not only balance the composition of our diet, but also to reduce the portions of food we consume. Every time we throw food into the waste bin, we are basically wasting resources and generating unnecessary environmental pressures. The wasted environmental value is higher for meat and animal-based food (Clune et al. 2017, Willett et al. 2019). A dietary shift combined with reducing our food waste might help us to reach important sustainability targets in terms of climate change and water use (Willett et al. 2019). In Spain, for example, the WF of food waste accounts for 2095 hm³, equivalent to 131 litres per person per day (Blas et al. 2018).

Health: Energy intake (calories) should be in balance with energy expenditure (WHO, 2018). Excess energy intake (i.e. energy-dense unhealthy dietary patterns) has been identified as the most significant dietary factor in relation to weight gain and the development of obesity (Roberts et al., 2002).